

then. Father and I had been hiking daily. I was a nut about wildlife at that time— loved critters of all forms. One day we were out hiking and looking for antelope. Father was walking and talking. I was looking for antelope. We were way the heck away from the car, maybe four miles, in the high plateau, sparse chaparral. Summer clouds started to fill the sky, and we started drifting back toward the car. Quickly the clouds turned deadly dark. Out of nowhere, it cooled, and lightening and hail pounded all around us— huge golf-ball-sized hail stones hitting us. We ran for the car. Lightening was striking everywhere. We should have flattened our-selves to the ground; but I was young and stupid and he didn't know any better, and we kept running. Lightening strikes hit the ground ten and twenty-five feet from us over and over, and we were terrified. The hail was hitting my father on the top of his head, and he was holding his head and running. I was fifteen and reasonably athletic. He was fifty- nine and could keep up with me running without much problem because he had those legs that wouldn't quit. We finally made it to the car and piled into it. The lightening continued all around, but we were finally safe—and I never saw my father laugh so hard. He had run so hard that he didn't worry for an hour.

In the early 1980's, Father had some bad experiences walking from the San Francisco depot to his office and back, including not watching where he was going and bonking his head on a metal post once, pass-ing out once, and getting accosted by a wanna-be mugger once. And, so, mother and I convinced him to follow my lead by letting me move his office down the peninsula, something I had done in 1977. I moved him and set up his office in San Mateo in a little office building on Fifth and El Camino Real. He continued to walk from home to work every day and loved it. Gardens. No muggers. Few stop lights or crazy taxi drivers to dodge. Beautiful flowers. No worries.

As mentioned earlier, late in his life, my father started falling down in his garden on Sundays. It was an early warning of dementia's onset, but no one saw it as such at the time. In retrospect, I can see that there were other signs of it back then. But I knew nothing about dementia and couldn't recognize them. His father probably had Alzheimer's, too, but there was no such name for it back then. The early progression of the disease is often very hard to detect and impossible if you don't know what to look for, which none of us